of random risk and luck that swayed those actions one way or the other. But we don't have a magic wand. We have brains that prefer easy answers without much appetite for nuance. So identifying the traits we should emulate or avoid can be agonizingly hard.

Let me tell you another story of someone who, like Bill Gates, was wildly successful, but whose success is hard to pin down as being caused by luck or skill.

Cornelius Vanderbilt had just finished a series of business deals to expand his railroad empire.

One of his business advisors leaned in to tell Vanderbilt that every transaction he agreed to broke the law.

"My God, John," said Vanderbilt, "You don't suppose you can run a railroad in accordance with the statutes of the State of New York, do you?"[10]

My first thought when reading this was: "That attitude is why he was so successful." Laws didn't accommodate railroads during Vanderbilt's day. So he said "to hell with it" and went ahead anyway.

Vanderbilt was wildly successful. So it's tempting to view his law-flouting—which was notorious and vital to his success—as sage wisdom. That scrappy visionary let nothing get in his way!

But how dangerous is that analysis? No sane person would recommend flagrant crime as an entrepreneurial trait. You can easily imagine Vanderbilt's story turning out much different—an outlaw whose young company collapsed under court order.

So we have a problem here.

You can praise Vanderbilt for flouting the law with as much passion as you criticize Enron for doing the same. Perhaps one got lucky by avoiding the arm of the law while the other found itself on the side of risk.

John D. Rockefeller is similar. His frequent circumventing of the law—a judge once called his company "no better than a common thief"—is often portrayed by historians as cunning business smarts. Maybe it was. But when does the narrative shift from, "You didn't let outdated laws get in the way of